American Yellowwood

Cladrastis kentukea

Family: Not stated Also known as: —

GARDENS Passage: 2 **TOTAL 2**



Summer / form
Library candidate



Fall color
Library candidate



Flower
Library candidate

Not available

Leaf close-up
Not available

QUICK FACTS & PLANTING

Type: Tree
Evergreen/Deciduous: Deciduous
Mature size: 30–50 ft. Confirmed by Missouri Botanical Garden, Gardenia, Morton Arboretum, EastLake Tree (Atlanta). × 40–55 ft. Confirmed.
Hardiness / Zone 8a: Suitable for Zone 8a. Hardy Zones 4–8. Native to southeastern U.S. including Georgia. Performs well in Atlanta. Tolerant of heat and adaptable soils. Best in full sun with protection from strong winds.
Restart pass (2026-10-13): NC State confirms graceful form, yellow-orange fall color, deep roots. Existing pruning notes already cited. [https://plants.ces.ncsu.edu/plants/cladrastis-kentukea/]
Sun: Full sun. Tolerates light shade.
Water: Medium. Prefers moist, well-drained soil. Drought tolerant once established.
Soil: Well-drained. Adaptable pH (acid to alkaline). Prefers fertile. Avoid compacted or poorly drained soils.
Growth rate: Not stated
Not stated
Planting:
Siting: Plant in full sun in well-drained soil. Protect from strong winds.
Water regularly until established. Prune in summer (winter/spring pruning causes bleeding). Suitable as specimen or shade tree. Minimal maintenance once established.
Soil prep: Well-drained. Adaptable pH (acid to alkaline). Prefers fertile. Avoid compacted or poorly drained soils.
Depth/spacing: Not stated
Season: Not stated
Establishment: Not stated

ORIGIN, CHARACTERISTICS & HEALTH

Origin / native: Native to restricted range in southeastern U.S. on limestone bluffs, ridges, and rich woodlands. One of the rarer eastern North American trees. Heartwood historically used for yellow dye.
Form / habit: Deciduous. Medium tree. Broad, rounded crown. Upright to spreading branches. Moderate growth.
Foliage: Clear yellow.
Flowers / fruit: Not stated
Bark / stem: Smooth gray, beech-like.
Not stated
Health:
Health notes: Generally resistant to pests and diseases. No serious problems commonly stated. Protect from strong winds (wood can be brittle; limbs break easily). Verticillium wilt may occur. Prune only in summer to prevent bleeding; corrective pruning often needed to eliminate weak branch forks. [NC State Plant Toolbox: https://plants.ces.ncsu.edu/plants/cladrastis-kentukea/]
Open: Specific Zone 8a incidence is thin.
Not stated
Additional:
- Fragrant white flowers in large drooping panicles (late spring). - Pinnately compound leaves (7–11 leaflets). - Smooth gray bark. - Yellow fall color. - Flowers may not appear every year on young trees. - Attracts pollinators.